

CITIUS, ALTIUS, FORTIUS

The original Olympics motto is made up of **three Latin words:** Citius, Altius, Fortius. These words mean Faster, Higher and Stronger, respectively.

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There was no one who ran faster at the Olympics than Noah Lyles. There was no one who jumped higher than Mondo Duplantis. There was no one who was stronger than Lasha Talakhadze.

Lyles seems a bit of a braggart. When he comes into the Olympics, the reigning world champion in the 100m says he's the fastest man even when Kishane Thompson of Jamaica has actually run the quickest time in the world. When he talks, part of you can't help but wonder if he can actually back it up.

An overwhelming majority of the global athletics community wants to see him fail just because he's so arrogant. Lyles though doesn't fade.

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Mondo seems to have a penchant for theatrics as much as Lyles does. His work wasn't done behind a microphone but on the field. When he had the height of the pole vault bar set at 6.25m – 1cm more than his own world record – he had the entire crowd of 69,000 cheering him on. The adoration of the crowd was anyway a given. He also had his competitors, those who might have once wanted to beat him, asking the crowd to get behind him.

When he did clear that height, there was almost a sense of inevitability to it.

While Lyles' race is close, Mondo competes, not against others, but himself. Regardless of how they won their gold medals, the fact is when you watch the two of them you see two athletes at the peak of their athletic careers. They are young — Lyles is 27, Mondo is 24 and both have many years of peak performance left in front of them.

That's not true for Lasha. Anymore that is. He's competing at his third Olympics. At any of his previous two, the notion of Lasha not placing on the top of the podium wouldn't even have been entertained.

Mondo took a surprising fourth-place finish at the Monaco Diamond League last year. Lyles has been beaten multiple times in 2024 itself including in the semifinals of the 100m at the Olympics.

Not Lasha though. For the last nine years — dating back to the 2015 World Championships, he has been unbeaten in international